

Congress candidates reported a five-fold rise in their assets. Mercifully, wealth doesn't always ensure success. In all, 365 crorepatris contested the Lok Sabha elections in 2004; 88 lost their deposits, and 114 came second. Last December in Delhi the Congress learnt this important lesson again when they found that Congress candidates who lost in Delhi were on an average richer than those who won. But wealth clearly does matter, all other things being constant.

The caveat emptor here, as with all matters concerning transparency in public life, is that we are going by what the political class has chosen to declare. After all, the statement of assets filed by candidates is at best a confession of sorts mandated by two Supreme Court judgements of May 2002 and March 2003. There are several gaps in the information available. Of the 542 Lok Sabha members, details of assets are available for only 522. Similarly in the Rajya Sabha, only 215 members have filed details of assets. There is no institutional mechanism to cross-check facts, nor is there a requirement for candidates to declare the source of wealth, or the increase in wealth of candidates in subsequent declarations. In Mizoram for instance, none of the 10 top candidates have reported possessing a PAN card even though their wealth is in excess of Rs 1 crore.

What is worse is that although MPs who are ministers file annual statements of their assets, the information is not available to the public. This virtually negates the concept of scrutiny that would prevent misuse of position of power and enrichment. Indeed, what should be openly available is denied even under the Right to Information Act. It is tragic that the Office of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh—who has been described as integrity personified—has been made party to this decision to deny the information. Again, while Central ministers are required to file a statement of assets, there is no such requirement for ministers in states (see



Wealth LEADERSHIP

6 MAM Ramaswamy

Janata Dal (Secular)
Rajya Sabha, Karnataka

Total Assets Rs 107.7 cr

7 Anand Singh

BJP
MLA, Vijayanagara, Karnataka

Total Assets Rs 239 cr

8 Anil V. Salgaocar

Independent
MLA, Sanvordem, Goa

Total Assets Rs 91.4 cr

9 N.A. Haris

Indian National Congress
MLA, Shanti Nagar, Karnataka

Total Assets Rs 85.3 cr

10 Mahendra Mohan

Samajwadi Party
Rajya Sabha, Uttar Pradesh

Total Assets Rs 85 cr

Denying Transparency. www.india-today.com). The adulterous cohabitation of power and pelf is conspicuous across the political spectrum. The chasm between the declared and perceived reality is all too obvious to be missed. Contrast the wealth reported and wealthy lifestyles of those elected to high office. Clearly the tip of the benami iceberg has not even been touched. In a country with a stark asymmetry in opportunities and ability, political power enables bending and twisting of policy, converting politics into the elevator politicians ride to reach the pot of gold. Living room conversations in middle and upper middle class homes are dotted with whose son, daughter or son-in-law is raking it in using the benami route to accumulate property and assets.

Television footage of currency notes being waved in Parliament during the last trust vote, the airborne campaigns witnessed during the polls in Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, money spent in fielding dummy candidates, funding of party offices, travel in Toyota suvs costing over Rs 75 lakh each and private charters that politicians avail of to fly within the country are all pointers that are hard to ignore. Bankers and brokers talk in not so hushed tones about the role of politicians in corporate scams. There is also speculation about the real beneficiary and benami ownership of at least two airlines, several real estate ventures, pharmaceutical units and infrastructure companies. The corporate concept of 'sleeping partner' has a whole new connotation in the political world. As long as the real incomes, wealth and funding of politicians remain opaque, governance will continue to suffer and democracy will be rendered more often on the liability side in the balance sheet of development.

with Sangram K. Parhi and Shyamal Yadav

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